

# Takatāpui

## Executive Summary

Takatāpui have always existed within te ao Māori. Our bodies, identities, and expressions sit within whakapapa, tikanga, and whanaungatanga.

Yet colonial systems (health, education, justice, housing, religion) have failed to recognise, protect, or serve Takatāpui with dignity. The result has been preventable harm: poorer health outcomes, higher suicide risk, exclusion from care, and exposure to violence and discrimination.

Te Pāti Māori affirms that Takatāpui wellbeing is a core measure of Māori wellbeing. When Takatāpui are safe, affirmed, and supported, whānau are stronger and communities are healthier.

This policy ensures gender-affirming, mana tīnana, kaupapa Māori support across health, education, justice, housing, cultural development and community services, led by Takatāpui, delivered locally, and grounded in mana.

## Definitions

Our bodies, identities, relationships, and expressions are held within whakapapa, tikanga, and whanaungatanga. The historical meaning of Takatāpui as intimate companionship, discovered and reclaimed by Emeritus Professor Ngahuia Te Awekotuku and Lee Smith, has evolved to now include Māori with diverse genders, including whakawāhine, tangata ira tāne, irawhiti, irarere, non-binary, and trans identities; diverse sexualities, including those who identify as lesbian, gay, bisexual, or queer; and diverse sex characteristics, including intersex Māori. Gender identity and sexuality are distinct, and this policy does not treat one as a stand-in for the other. No Māori is required to use this word to belong; everyone holds the right to name their own identity.

## Context

Before colonisation, takatāpui Māori existed openly within whānau, hapū, and iwi structures. Diversity of identity, expression, and role was understood through whakapapa, tikanga, and relational responsibility.

Colonial systems imposed rigid gender norms, criminalised difference, and dismantled Māori systems of care. Health, education, justice, and social services were designed without Māori, and often against us. For takatāpui Māori, this compounded harm: racism layered with exclusion based on gender and sexuality.

Today, takatāpui Māori experience:

- Higher rates of mental distress and suicide risk
- Barriers to gender-affirming and culturally safe healthcare
- Discrimination and violence within public systems
- Exclusion from education, housing, and employment pathways.

At the same time, takatāpui Māori continue to lead, sustaining whānau, creating culture, caring for community, and holding space for future generations. Where kaupapa Māori, body-positive, and affirming services exist, wellbeing improves and harm reduces.

## Our Position

- Takatāpui are whole, valued, and complete.
- Nothing about Takatāpui without Takatāpui: Takatāpui must hold meaningful decision-making authority in the design, governance, commissioning, delivery, and evaluation of policies and services that primarily affect them.
- Wellbeing is achieved when systems affirm identity.
- Safety, belonging, and access to care are collective responsibilities grounded in whānau and whakapapa.
- Takatāpui whaikaha/whānau hauā face compounded barriers across health, housing, justice, and social systems, and must be named and resourced explicitly.

# Te Pāti Māori will...

**1. Establish a Takatāpui Commission to hold agencies accountable for delivering this policy**

- Takatāpui-governed, with real decision-making authority over how Takatāpui-specific funding is allocated to community-led organisations
- Guaranteed, ring-fenced funding transferred by Te Puni Kōkiri each year, with no ministerial discretion over the amount, timing, or whether it occurs
- Subject to public annual reporting and independent audit oversight.

**2. Protect Takatāpui from Violence and Hate**

- Recognise and respond to hate-motivated harm against Takatāpui including political, legislative, and religious attacks
- Prioritise prevention, community safety, and restorative justice
- Ensure Takatāpui are protected without expanding carceral systems
- Update the Human Rights Act to identify specific provisions for people with diverse genders, sexualities and innate variations of sex characteristics
- Name and respond to the specific needs of Takatāpui rangatahi currently in Oranga Tamariki care and youth justice settings
- Name and respond to the specific needs of Takatāpui whaikaha/whānau hauā currently experiencing residential care.

**3. Grow Takatāpui Cultural Leadership**

- Support Takatāpui pathways to te reo Māori and tikanga fluency
- Support whānau, hapū, iwi and Māori community led wānanga
- Fund Takatāpui-led creative and cultural expression as an investment in Māori cultural continuity
- Ensure whaikaha/whānau hauā lead accessibility at all stages and levels of cultural development.

**4. Guarantee Gender-Affirming, Kaupapa Māori Healthcare**

Fund and deliver gender-affirming healthcare within the public system, including:

  - Hormone therapy
  - Primary and specialist care
  - Pathways to gender-affirming surgery where clinically indicated
  - Protection for intersex Takatāpui from non-consensual or medically unnecessary intervention, with bodily autonomy, informed consent, and access to medical records upheld as rights distinct from, not folded into, gender-affirming care
  - For intersex tamariki specifically, prevent gender normalising surgery

- Ensure services are mana-tīnana, culturally safe, and Takatāpui-led
- Ensure appropriate services for whaikaha/whānau hauā are designed and led by them
- Invest in growing the kaupapa Māori and Takatāpui health workforce, so Takatāpui and Māori-led services come with the clinicians and kaimahi to deliver them.

### 5. Strengthen Takatāpui Mental Health & Suicide Prevention

- Invest in Takatāpui-led kaupapa Māori mental health services
- Integrate Takatāpui support within Māori suicide prevention strategies
- Recognise the compounding barriers to positive social outcomes faced by Takatāpui who are also whaikaha/whānau hauā, and guarantee their proportionate representation within all Takatāpui decision-making processes established under this policy, in line with Te Pāti Māori's Disabilities Policy
- Ensure crisis services are affirming, competent, and accessible nationwide.

### 6. Invest in Takatāpui-Led Housing Solutions

- Resource Takatāpui organisations to identify and design housing communities for rangatahi to whānau to kaumātua-kuia
- Support Takatāpui organisations to access appropriate existing housing stock
- Ensure that housing is supportive of whaikaha/whānau hauā needs and aspirations.

### Funding Commitment

Te Pāti Māori will commit $200 million over three years to deliver real, nationwide coverage, including:

- Establishment of a Takatāpui Commission
- Health services (affirming care, surgery pathways, mental health)
- Education support and safety programmes
- Housing accessibility
- Violence prevention and justice responses
- Takatāpui-led creative, cultural, and leadership development in te reo and on marae
- Capacity and capability-building for Takatāpui organisations.

### Our Commitment

We commit to:

- Uplifting Takatāpui mana
- Protecting mokopuna futures
- Establishing an independent Takatāpui Commission, Takatāpui-governed, holding real decision-making authority over how Takatāpui-specific funding is allocated to community-led organisations
- Requiring Te Puni Kōkiri, as administering department, to transfer the Commission's appropriated funding across Votes Health, Social Development, Housing and Urban Development, and Māori Development in full and within a fixed statutory timeframe each year, with no ministerial discretion over the amount, timing, or whether the transfer occurs
- The Commission's use of funding is subject to public annual reporting and existing independent audit oversight
- Growing Takatāpui fluency in te reo Māori, participation on marae, and pathways into cultural leadership roles
- Supporting Takatāpui cultural growth including te reo Takatāpui.

This policy is essential to building a more inclusive and equitable society within Aotearoa where homophobia and transphobia are no longer acceptable. We are calling for a stop to political, legislative, and religious developments that deny and marginalise Takatāpui in Aotearoa.